and explicitly developmentalist team. However, in 2014, previously fleeting hints of political and economic scandal cascaded into full-blown corruption cases involving many senior politicians, the majority from the PT, and Petrobras, Brazil's largest and most revered company, public or private.[249] Due to a combination of Rousseff's own failures of leadership and political institutions making executive-legislative stalemate likely at the best of times,[250] what could have been a manageable series of crises sent the country into a downward spiral, escalating just after her close reelection in October 2014 and continuing through her removal from office in mid-2016. As a consequence, the mood surrounding Brazil's participation in internationally oriented initiatives, from the plans for the 2016 Rio de Janeiro Olympics to the BRICS, became increasingly desperate.

China—the PT's Investor of Last Resort?

This shift over time was particularly obvious in the changing views about China of senior policymakers and opinion leaders in Brazil. BRICS cooperation from the beginning offered the hope of managing an increasingly intense, and sometimes problematic, economic relationship with China. Since about 2000, Brazil's international economic ties with China have deepened and thickened extremely rapidly. In a decade, China, in Brazilian eyes, transformed from being a relatively unimportant country, to holding the status of a possible development model, to being viewed in some of the more excitable corners of the senior policy apparatus as a possible financial savior.[251] In 2009, China became the country's major trading partner, displacing the United States, which had enjoyed that status for many decades.

BRICS euphoria among senior politicians notwithstanding, other Brazilians, especially more market-oriented (i.e., "neoliberal") economists and business leaders with economic policy preferences closer to those of the center-right coalition led by President Cardoso, worried about the wisdom of replacing much-criticized asymmetrical interdependence with the United States with asymmetrical, and more opaque, ties with China. The economic and financial relationship with China is much discussed, and not infrequently criticized, in Brazil's elite press.[252] For example, the downside of the post-2000 "commodity supercycle" that benefited Brazil, with swelling Chinese demand for raw materials and food, including Brazilian